

Before doing so, however, I believe it is necessary to provide my readers with the poem itself, the text that surrounds it, and with the phonetic interpretation of Jie text, based on the recent advances in Chinese historical phonology.

The two-line poem in question is recorded in the biography of Fotu Cheng in the volume 95 of the "Jin shu [晉書, History of Jin]."⁵ The Jin dynasty ruled from 280 to 420 C.E., but the text itself was compiled under Song dynasty. The episode connected with the poem is as follows:

及曜自攻洛陽，勒將救之，其群下咸諫以為不可。勒以訪澄，澄曰：「相輪鈴音云：『秀支替戾岡，僕谷劬秃當。』此羯語也。秀支，軍也。替戾岡，出也。僕谷，劉曜胡位也。劬秃當，捉也。此言軍出捉得曜也。」又令一童子潔齋七日，取麻油合胭脂，躬自研掌中，舉手示童子，粲然有輝。童子驚曰：「有軍馬甚眾，見一人長大白皙，以朱糸縛其肘。」澄曰：「此即曜也。」勒甚悅，遂赴洛拒曜，生擒之。

Then [Liu] Yao himself attacked Loyang, and [Shi] Le was going to rescue it. All his retainers [tried] to persuade [Shi Le] that [he] would not be able to do it. [Shi] Le visited [Futo] Cheng with [this problem], and Cheng said: "It is said in Xianlun Lingyin: "S(l)u(s)-ke thij?-re(ts)-kang bok-kok Ko-thok-tang." This is Jie language. S(l)u(s)-ke means "army", thij?-re(ts)-kang is "to go out". Bok-kok is the barbarian title of Liu Yao, Ko-thok-tang means "to catch." These words mean that army/armies will go out and capture [Liu] Yao." [Cheng] also ordered a young boy to purify himself and fast for seven days, and [then] he mixed hemp oil with rouge, studied [the mixture] himself on his palm, and then showed his hand to the boy. It was clearly shining. The boy said with surprise: "There are many war horses, and [I] see a man, tall and big, and clearly white (Liu Yao was an albino – A.V.). His elbows are tied by a red rope." [Futo] Cheng said: "This is definitely [Liu] Yao." [Shi]

5 I use an edition of the "Jin shu" published by Zhonghua shuju (Beijing, 1988). "Jin shu" was compiled by Fang Xuanling and other scholars in the beginning of Tang dynasty, that roughly corresponds to the beginning of the seventh century C.E. The events described in this passage refer to the war between two Xiong-nu chieftains, Liu Yao and Shi Le for the dominance in North China, that occurred in 329 C.E.